

A Partial ECLIPSE

India may have been the global capitalists' favourite story. But on the ground, it trails on human development indicators.

| By Nivedita Mukherjee |

Between India Shining and *Jai Ho*, through four years of high growth that India became the story of global markets, not much has changed on the ground, it would seem. Between aspirational Indians vying for better and richer lifestyles, there are millions still below the poverty line. Between huge capital inflows, impressive growth rates and big-ticket acquisitions across the globe, there is still an India trapped in abysmally, and by now customarily, low rankings in crucial human development indicators. Between global opinion makers waxing eloquent on India's big growth story and bullish investors, there is still an influential chunk for whom India scores pathetically on economic freedom and competitiveness. The paradox goes on.

Blame it on the decades-old bane of policy dividends not reaching the grassroots or tendency of global monitors to overlook positives, the fact is that the power of spin doctors to transform moments of embarrassment and shame into heady celebrations of "arrival" on the global stage is not being reflected in the global indices. The most noteworthy point is that unlike India, countries like Sri Lanka, Bolivia, Namibia and Guinea with lesser spending on social improvement are climbing up the ranks with every new report. Take the Global Hunger Index developed by the International Food Policy Research Institute (IFPRI). According to the index, India, with its high food prices and at 66th position, ranks below even Bangladesh in two important components—underweight children and child mortality. IFPRI

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is India's rank in transport and communication, lower than Croatia, Cyprus, Jordan and even Latvia, says the WEF.



UN HUMAN DEVELOPMENT REPORT, 2008 From 127 in 2004, India has slipped to 132 in the Human Development Index, scoring below Equatorial Guinea and the Solomon Islands.



UNICEF STATE OF THE WORLD'S CHILDREN, 2009 Infant mortality rates have improved from 67/1,000 to 57/1,000 live births since 2004, but India trails even Mali on this count.



IFPRI GLOBAL HUNGER REPORT, 2009 India, at 66th position, ranks below Bangladesh in underweight children and child mortality.



IFC/WB DOING BUSINESS REPORT, 2009 India is the most difficult country to enforce contracts in a court or otherwise. At 122, it trails Nepal and Bangladesh.



WEF GLOBAL COMPETITIVENESS REPORT, 2008 With its inadequate infrastructure, inefficient bureaucracy and tight labour laws, India, at 50th position, is no match for China.

Illustration by SAURABH SINGH. Graphic by PRASHANT CHAUDHARY

says India, Yemen, and Timor-Leste have the highest prevalence of underweight children under five—more than 40 per cent in all three countries. "All this puts India third on the malnourished children's chart but only from the bottom," says Purnima Menon of IFPRI.

No doubt India, like other countries, is reeling under spiralling food and fuel prices, which have set the clock back on tackling hunger and malnutrition issues, but what pulls down its status is the ineffectiveness of programmes like the Public Distribution System and the Mid-Day Meal Scheme that need an urgent revamp. Food security is not the only parameter on which India ranks low. Its track record is as unflattering in meeting the Millennium Development Goals (MDGs) set by the UN, notably reduction of poverty, bridging the gender gap and improvement in healthcare. Despite flaunting the world's second highest economic growth rate, India